and financial services ended up in American hands. To safeguard American strategic and economic interests on the island, the United States made alliances with the local landowning elite and the military. By far the most trusted American ally in the presidential office in Havana became General Fulgencio Batista, who served as president of Cuba between 1940 and 1944, returning to power in 1952 as a result of a military coup. He developed close ties with the two most powerful American economic forces on the island, the agricultural corporations and the Mafia clans. Gambling and prostitution catering to American tourists became thriving industries.[8]

Upon his return to Cuba, Batista canceled the impending presidential elections. His corrupt rule antagonized not only the poor but also the middle class. With elections canceled and democracy under attack, dissatisfied young people took up arms. On July 23, 1953, a group of young revolutionaries staged an attack on the Moncada Barracks in Santiago. The assault was repelled and its leaders arrested. Among the latter was a twenty-six-year-old lawyer and descendant of a wealthy landowning family, Fidel Castro, who was sentenced to a fifteen-year term. His younger brother, Raúl, and twenty-four more participants in the attack were also imprisoned.

Luckily for the Castro brothers and their coconspirators, they were released in May 1955 as Batista sought to improve his international image. Fearing a new arrest, the Castro brothers left Cuba for Mexico. The Moncada Barracks story seemed to be over. Batista had survived the assault, conducted fraudulent elections, and got the rebels out of the country, all to the satisfaction of his American allies, who wanted to safeguard their assets without turning American and world public opinion against themselves. To the surprise of many, the Castro brothers were back in Cuba by November 1956, with Fidel leading a group of Cuban and Latin American revolutionaries. They arrived illegally on a leaky yacht, the *Granma*, to start a new revolt.

The guerrilla warfare that would eventually bring down Batista began with a major setback. Government troops attacked the *Granma* rebels soon after their landing, forcing them to seek refuge in the Sierra Maestra mountains of Oriente province, in southeastern Cuba. Of the initial group of eighty-one rebels only nineteen, including Fidel and Raúl Castro and their close ally, the Argentinian doctor Ernesto “Che” Guevara, made it to the